Reworded prompt: "How are marketing companies marketing in the AI era?"

For David to paste into Manus, ChatGPT, Gemini, Qwen, Claude, etc. (written 2026-10-12). Built from the failures in round one: Qwen hallucinated building software, Gemini was thin, ChatGPT cited nothing, Manus aimed at enterprise, nobody flagged vendor hype.

I'm a US Army veteran. I run marketing and tech for a local pest control company, and I'm building a SaaS platform that gives small service businesses their phone system, CRM, scheduling, and marketing in one place. I am not an enterprise marketing department. Answer for my world: local service businesses (pest control, plumbing, HVAC, roofing, lawn care) with small budgets and no marketing staff.

Question: How are marketing companies actually marketing in the AI era in 2026?

Rules:
1. Research, don't vibes. Cite real sources with names and dates for every major claim: studies, surveys, platform announcements, earnings calls. If a number comes from a vendor selling the fix, label it [vendor claim]. If you can't source a claim, mark it unverified or drop it.
2. Never invent statistics. If a widely repeated stat has no traceable source, say so explicitly.
3. Do not write code, build tools, or claim you ran, tested, or created anything. Words only, and answer the question I asked, not a related one.
4. Separate proven from hype. For each tactic: who is really doing it, what it costs (real price ranges), and which results are documented vs merely promised.
5. Translate enterprise into small business. If a tactic needs a huge budget or a data team, say so, then give the small-budget version or admit there isn't one.
6. Cover at minimum: AI search visibility (GEO/AEO), speed-to-lead and AI answering (voice, chat, text), content and short-form video, paid ads including ads inside AI assistants, reviews and reputation, first-party data and CRM follow-up, and how agencies price all this now (retainers, outcome fees, hybrids) in real dollars.
7. End with three things: (a) the 5 moves a one-person operator should make first, in order, with rough cost and time for each; (b) the 3 most overhyped claims in AI marketing right now, with your evidence; (c) anything you found that surprised you or contradicts the consensus.
8. Write plain. Short paragraphs, tables where they help. No buzzword stuffing: if you use a term like "agentic" or "hyper-personalization," define it in one plain sentence the first time.

Optional follow-up probe (send after it answers, to test honesty)

Now be your own skeptic. Go through the report you just gave me and list every claim you cannot actually back with a source you found, every number that came from a

vendor, and anything you overstated. Then give me the corrected version of your top 5 takeaways, with confidence levels.